STERLING

Five follow-up runs

Did the fixes hold? An AI tool built the same screen with Sterling, five times from scratch.

Sterling, a design system designed and built with Claude Code, under my direction.

mcasey10.github.io/sterling-design-system/runs/

FIVE FOLLOW-UP RUNS

The question, and how I tested it

During version 1.2, an AI coding tool built the Pool loans screen from Sterling.

Review found three problems in Sterling itself, which I fixed.

But one run proves less than it seems.

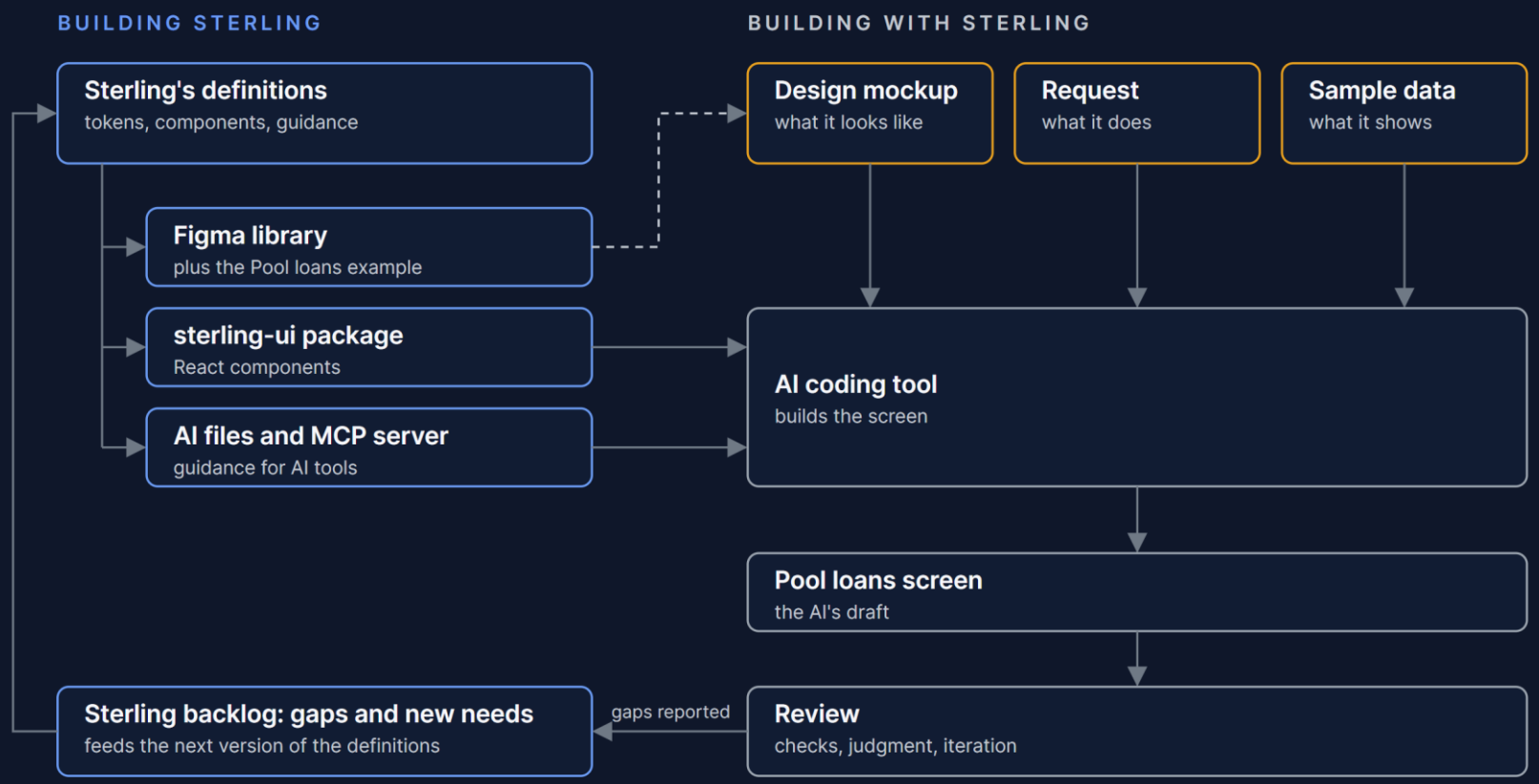
HOW

- Five fresh sessions with the same kit: Sterling 1.2.0, the same request, mockup and data.
- Each could use only the kit.
- Every screen was scored the same way: a script fixed in advance, a transcript review, hands-on checks.

mcasey10.github.io/sterling-design-system/demo/

TWO BUILDS

One build makes Sterling. The other builds a screen with it, and what the review finds goes back into Sterling.



In a team: people building with Sterling refine the AI's draft and report gaps; the design system's owners decide what goes into the next version.

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THE THREE FIXES HELD · FIX 1

The data grid couldn't tell screen readers why a cell was flagged

Problem: Sterling's data grid had no way to attach the reason for a warning to a cell. To get it right, the first build bypassed the data grid: it wrote its own table and styled it with the data grid's internal styles. It worked, but the screen no longer used the component, so future improvements to the data grid would never reach it.

Fix: The data grid can now carry a reason for each cell.

Follow-up runs: All five used the data grid, and the reason is read out.

Looks the same before and after

LN-204389	Harbor Point Lending	305,600.00	702	⚠ 93.0%	⚠ Exception

BEFORE

The screen

Own table
styled with the data grid's internal styles

⚠ 93.0% + reason, added by the screen

Own table + the data grid's internal styles; the screen adds the reason itself.

A SCREEN READER HEARS
"93.0%, breaks a rule: LTV 93.0% — above 90%"

AFTER

The screen

Sterling's data grid
the component itself

⚠ 93.0% reason: LTV 93.0% — above 90%

Sterling's data grid; the reason travels with the cell.

A SCREEN READER HEARS
"Warning 93.0%, LTV 93.0% — above 90%"

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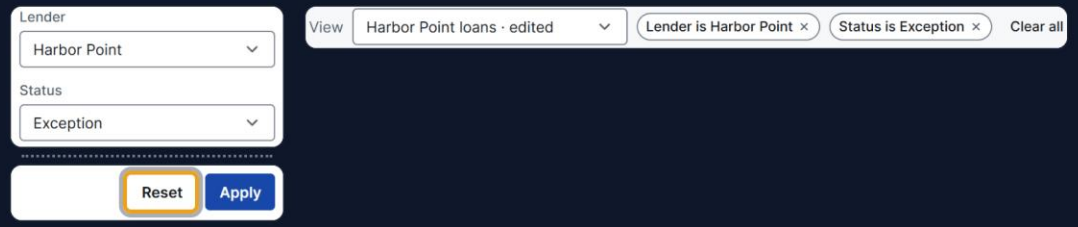
THE THREE FIXES HELD · FIX 2

Reset discarded the saved view's filters

Problem: The screen opens on a saved view (one lender's loans). Sterling's guidance said Reset clears every filter, and the first build did exactly that, so Reset also threw away the view's own filter.

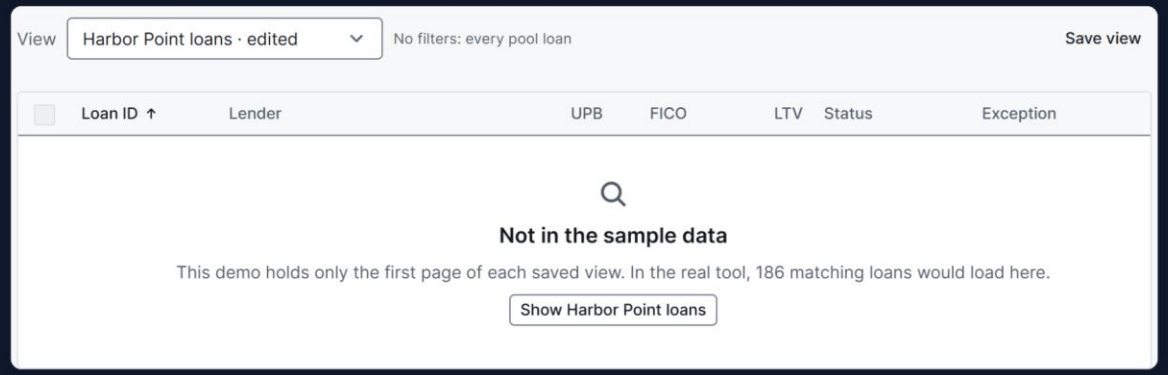
Fix: Sterling's guidance now says Reset returns to the view's filters. Clear all, beside the filter chips, removes every filter and shows all 186 loans.

Follow-up runs: All five return to the view's 58 loans.



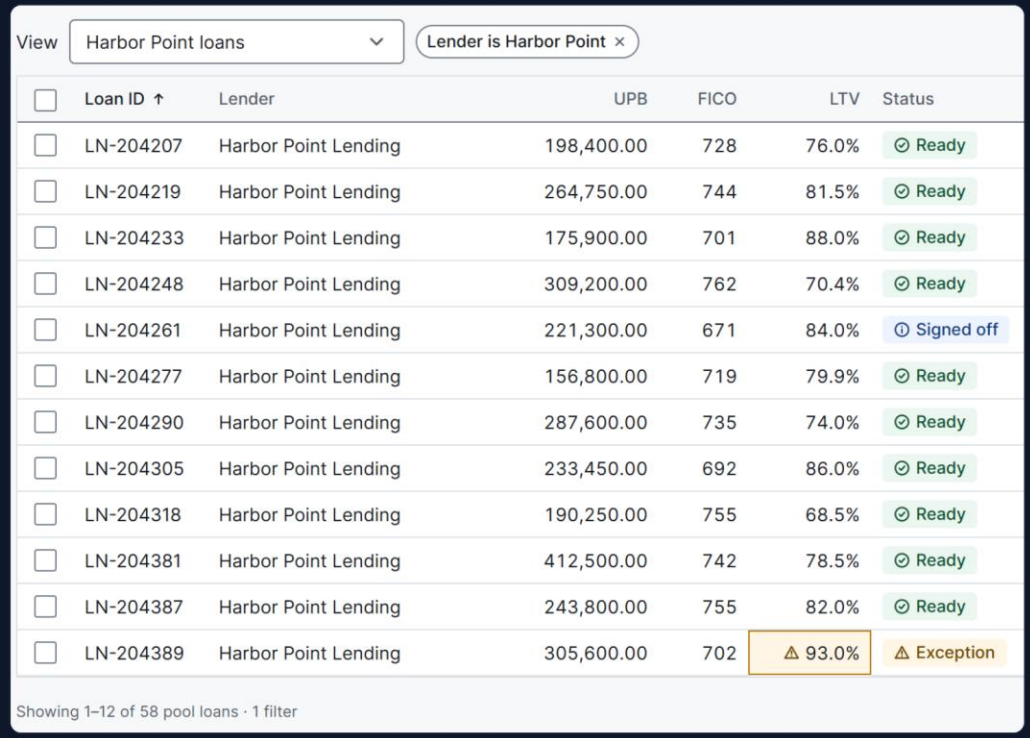
Before Reset: the Harbor Point loans view with a Status filter added. Both builds look the same here.

The first build



After Reset: the view's own Lender filter is removed too.

After the fixes (follow-up run)



After Reset: back to the view's Lender filter and its 58 loans.

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THE THREE FIXES HELD · FIX 3

The empty data grid's message didn't fit narrow screens

Problem: On a narrow screen, the message for an empty grid was centered on the grid's full width, not on the space you can see, so it was cut off.

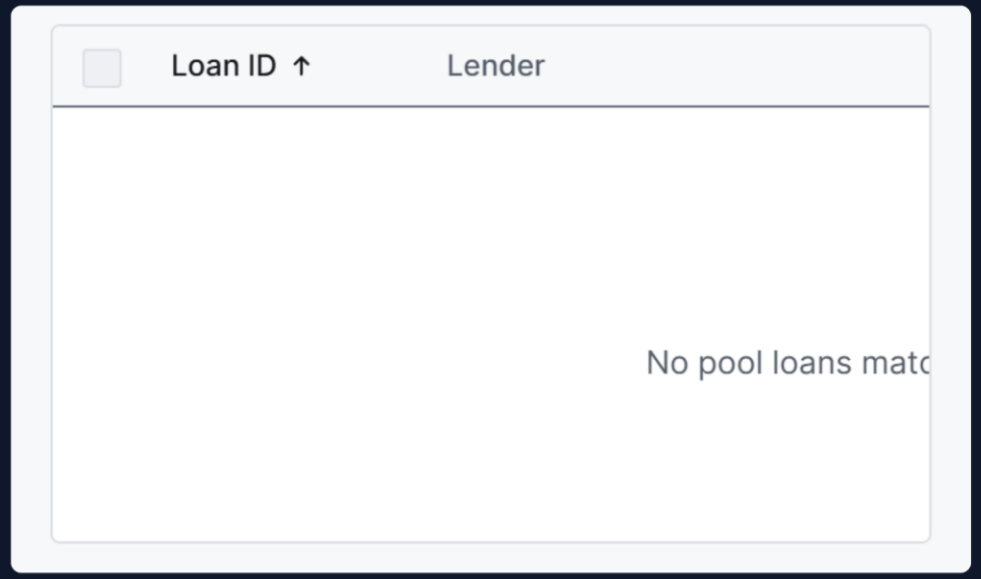
The first build's own table reused the data grid's internal styles, so it had the same flaw.

Fix: When there is no data to display, the message is now centered and wrapped within the visible space of the grid frame.

Follow-up runs: Fully visible in every run where it could be measured.

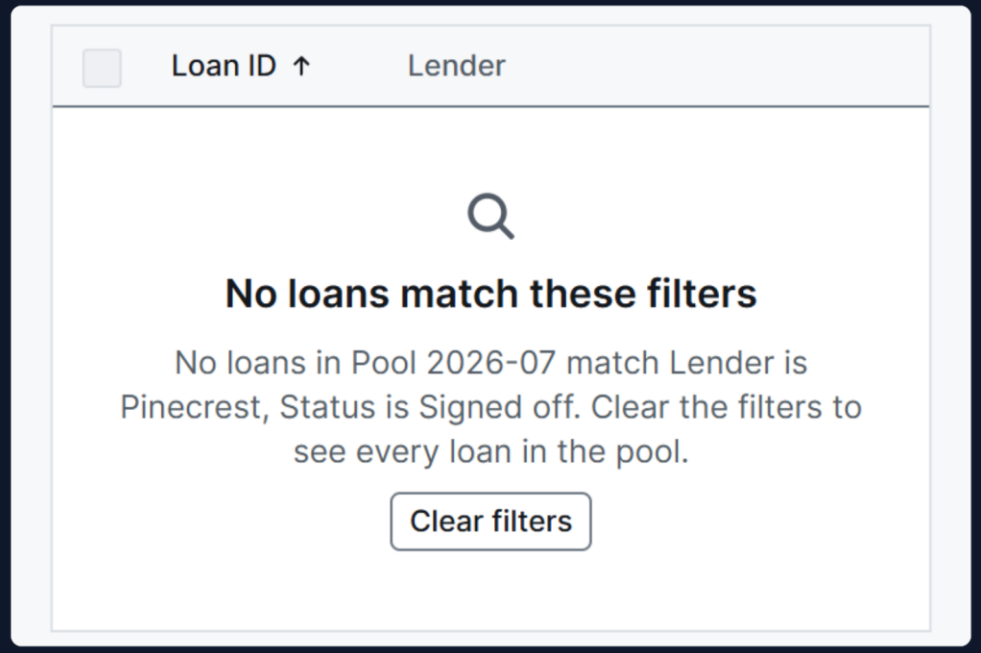
Assumes the page layout stacks on a narrow screen.

The first build



390 px wide: “No pool loans matc…”

After the fixes (follow-up run)



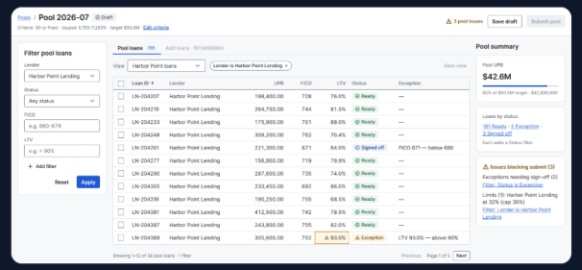
390 px wide: the whole message

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CONSISTENT WHERE THE REQUEST WAS CLEAR

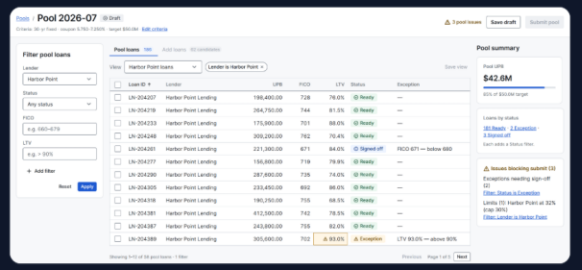
Five follow-up runs, each a new session with the same request, opened on the same screen.

Follow-up run 01



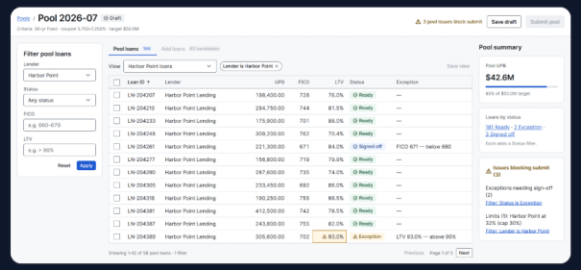
Build time **10 min 53 s**

Follow-up run 02



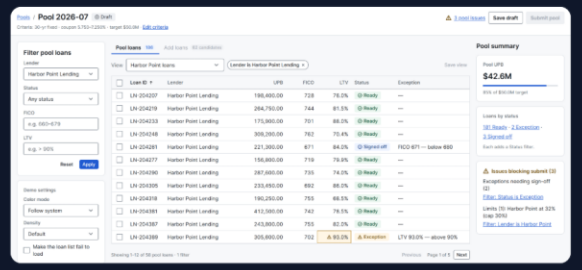
Build time **11 min 04 s**

Follow-up run 03



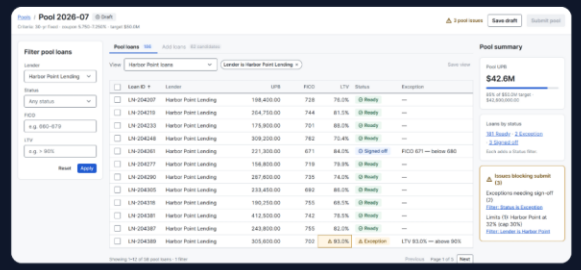
Build time **10 min 06 s**

Follow-up run 04



Build time **13 min 32 s**

Follow-up run 05



Build time **10 min 30 s**

Every run: all figures correct · all requested states built · no automated accessibility violations

Accessibility checked automatically in Light and Dark, in every density.

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STATES AND EDGE CASES

Every requested state, and the edge cases, in all five runs.

ITEM	RUN 01	RUN 02	RUN 03	RUN 04	RUN 05	HOW TESTED
REQUESTED STATES						
Loading skeleton rows under the header	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	checked by hand
Empty says why, and offers a way out	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	scored automatically
Error what failed, and Retry	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	checked by hand
Disabled actions Submit pool and Sign off, with a reason	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	scored automatically
Selection one, a range, the page, all 58	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	scored automatically
Bulk action bar only while rows are selected	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	scored automatically
Sign-off a note is required; counts update	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	scored automatically
EDGE CASES						
Long lender names truncate; the row keeps its height	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	scored automatically
A filter with no results the empty state	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	scored automatically
“Any lender” no Lender filter and no chip	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	scored automatically
Clear all removes every filter: 186 loans	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	scored automatically
Loans not in the sample no rows or totals invented	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled	✓ Handled; wording noted	checked automatically, recorded as a note

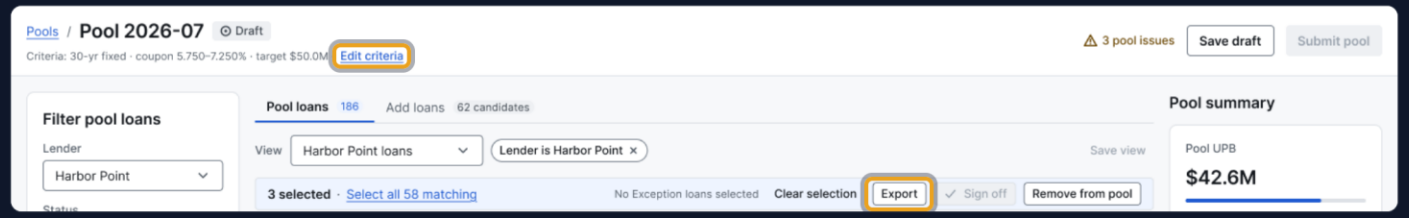
“Wording noted”: run 05’s empty state counted all 186 pool loans, though only the sample was filtered. Wording is noted, not scored.

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THE MOCKUP AND THE REQUEST DIDN'T AGREE

The mockup showed Export and Edit criteria. The request mentioned neither, and the runs differed.

Design mockup



Export and Edit criteria, outlined

THE REQUEST

What the trader can do

- Select loans, one at a time, a range, the page, or all 58 that match.
- Sign off the selected exceptions. A note is required. If no exception is selected, signing off isn't available, and the screen says why.
- Remove the selected loans from the pool. This can be undone, so ask for confirmation only when the selection goes beyond the loans on screen.

Not mentioned: Export or Edit criteria.

	BULK ACTION BAR, THREE LOANS SELECTED	EXPORT	EDIT CRITERIA
Follow-up run 01	3 selected · Select all 58 matching · No Exception loans selected · Clear selection · Sign off · Remove from pool	⊖ Left out, said so	⬚ Placeholder
Follow-up run 02	3 selected · Select all 58 matching · No Exception loans selected · Clear selection · Export · Sign off · Remove from pool	⊕ Added a CSV download, said so	⬚ Placeholder
Follow-up run 03	3 selected · Select all 58 matching · No Exception loans selected · Clear selection · Sign off · Remove from pool	⊖ Left out, said so	⊖ Left out
Follow-up run 04	3 selected · Select all 58 matching · No Exception loans selected · Clear selection · Sign off · Remove from pool	⊖ Left out, said so	⬚ Placeholder
Follow-up run 05	3 selected · Select all 58 matching · No Exception loans selected · Clear selection · Sign off · Remove from pool	⊖ Left out, said so	⊖ Left out

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PATTERNS FILLED THE GAPS

Not described in the request; built the same way in all five runs.

FEATURE	RUN 01	RUN 02	RUN 03	RUN 04	RUN 05	DESCRIBED BY
View menu pick a saved set of filters	✓ Built	✓ Built	✓ Built	✓ Built	✓ Built	Saved views pattern
Save view save the current filters by name	✓ Built	✓ Built	✓ Built	✓ Built	✓ Built	Saved views pattern
Summary links a count in the summary adds a filter	✓ Built	✓ Built	✓ Built	✓ Built	✓ Built	Link component guidance

Where the request was silent, all five matched what Sterling's guidance describes.

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FIVE FOLLOW-UP RUNS

What it means

LESSONS

- Check AI-drafted requirements against their source.
- Written-down patterns give consistent behavior without spelling it out.
- Let your AI tool see what it builds.

WHAT THE RUNS EXPOSED IN STERLING

- Every run (5 of 5) styled Sterling's internal class names, which Sterling never says are private.
- One run (1 of 5) didn't stack its layout on a narrow screen, where Sterling has no rule yet.
- Both are on the backlog.

LIMITS AND NEXT

- A best case: the screen Sterling was designed for, with a mockup from its own example.
- One screen, one model, five runs.
- Next: a screen Sterling wasn't designed for.

The full record: github.com/mcasey10/sterling-design-system/tree/main/docs/demo/runs · mcasey10.github.io/sterling-design-system/runs/